

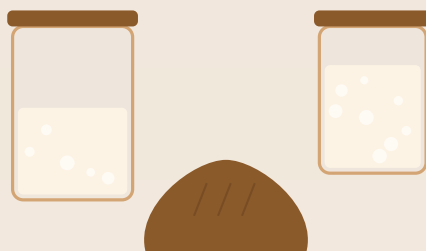
THE 7-Day Sourdough Starter Guide

Because every great bread starts with a happy starter

Your day-by-day companion for creating your first sourdough starter.
No experience needed. Just flour, water, and a little patience.

Rise & Ferment

riseandferment.com



Welcome, friend

I'm going to be honest with you from the start: the first time I tried to make a sourdough starter, I killed it. On day three. My two kids were sick, I forgot to feed it, and when I came back to it, it smelled like something died in my kitchen cupboard. I cried a little. Then I tried again.

And that second try? That's the one that changed everything in our house.

So if you're reading this thinking *"I can barely remember to water my plants, how am I going to keep a living culture alive?"* — welcome. You're my people.

This guide is written for you. Not for professional bakers. Not for food scientists. For busy humans with real lives who want to make something beautiful with their hands. Whether you're a parent juggling a thousand things, someone living alone looking for a meaningful new ritual, or just curious about this ancient craft — you belong here.

What you'll find inside:

- ✓ Day-by-day instructions (with what to expect at each stage)
- ✓ Everything you need to buy (it's less than you think)
- ✓ A troubleshooting cheat sheet for when things look scary
- ✓ Your first simple bread recipe
- ✓ A printable feeding schedule for your fridge

One important thing: sourdough isn't about perfection. It's about patience, consistency, and giving yourself grace when things don't go as planned. Your starter will forgive your mistakes — all it asks is that you keep trying.

Let's begin. You've got this.

Before you start: Shopping list

Here's everything you'll need for the next 7 days. Most of it is probably already in your kitchen.

Item	Details	Notes
Whole wheat or rye flour	500g bag	For days 1-3 (activates faster)
All-purpose white flour	1kg bag	For days 4+ onwards
Clean glass jar	500ml-1L	Any jar! Old jam jar works
Rubber band	1	To mark the level after feeding
Kitchen towel or loose lid	1	To cover (not airtight!)
Kitchen scale	1g precision	Best \$12 investment ever
Filtered or rested water	Room temp	Let tap water sit 1hr if chlorinated

Total cost to start: Under \$15 if you already have a jar and a towel. That's less than one loaf of artisan sourdough from the bakery.

Busy parent tip: Do not stress about getting "the right" flour. Any whole wheat or rye flour from the grocery store works perfectly. We're making bread, not launching a rocket.

Day 1

The Beginning

Meet your future starter

Time needed: 5 minutes

What to do:

- Weigh **50g whole wheat flour** (or rye) into your clean jar.
- Add **50g room-temperature water**.
- Stir vigorously for about 30 seconds — you want it well-mixed.
- Mark the level with a rubber band on the outside of the jar.
- Cover loosely (towel, loose lid, or plastic wrap with holes).
- Place somewhere warm (21-25°C / 70-77°F is ideal).

What to expect:

Honestly? Not much. It's just a paste right now. That's completely normal. The microorganisms are settling in, figuring out their new home. Think of it as move-in day.

***Tip:** Set a daily phone alarm right now. I feed mine right after breakfast. It becomes a 3-minute ritual that you don't even think about.*

*"You just took the first step. That jar of flour paste is about to become something magical.
Welcome to the journey."*

Day 2

First Check-In

Patience is your superpower

Time needed: 5 minutes

What to do:

- Look at your jar. Do you see any bubbles? Small changes? It's okay if not.
- **Discard** roughly half of the mixture (into compost or trash — we'll use discard later!).
- Add **50g whole wheat flour + 50g water**.
- Stir well. Re-mark the level with your rubber band.
- Cover and return to its warm spot.

What to expect:

You might see a few tiny bubbles, or nothing at all. Both are normal. The wild yeast in your flour is just starting to wake up. Don't panic if it looks exactly the same as yesterday.

***Tip:** Why do we discard? If we kept adding without removing, the jar would overflow AND the ratio of food-to-microbes would be off. Discarding keeps everything balanced.*

"Nothing dramatic today, and that's okay. The best things take time. You're doing great."

Day 3

The Funky Phase

Yes, that smell is normal

Time needed: 5 minutes

What to do:

- Open the jar. Take a sniff. Try not to make a face.
- You may see it has risen a bit and then fallen. Good!
- **Discard half** and feed: **50g whole wheat flour + 50g water**.
- Stir, mark, cover, return to warm spot.

What to expect:

This is the day that scares most beginners. Your starter might smell like nail polish remover, old cheese, or a chemistry experiment. **THIS IS COMPLETELY NORMAL**. The "bad" bacteria (*leuconostoc*) are producing off-smells, but they're about to be replaced by the good guys. Do NOT throw it out.

***Tip:** If it smells truly awful — that's actually a good sign. It means there's active fermentation happening. The smell will improve dramatically over the next few days.*

"Day 3 is where most people give up. Don't be most people. Your starter is fighting its own little battle right now, and the good guys are winning. Just keep feeding."

Day 4

The Quiet Before the Storm

Trust the process

Time needed: 5 minutes

What to do:

- Switch to **all-purpose white flour** starting today.
- **Discard half**, feed **50g white flour + 50g water**.
- Stir well. Mark. Cover.
- Watch for any rising between feedings.

What to expect:

Days 4-5 often go quiet. The initial burst of activity dies down as the early bacteria are replaced by lactobacillus (the ones you want). It might look like nothing is happening. Don't lose faith — this is a crucial transition.

***Tip:** Temperature matters a lot now. If your kitchen is below 20°C, try placing the jar on top of your fridge (warm from the motor), in the oven with just the light on, or near a radiator. This can speed things up dramatically.*

"The quiet days are the most important ones. Like anything worth having, the transformation happens invisibly before you see the results."

Day 5

Signs of Life

Hello, bubbles!

Time needed: 5 minutes

What to do:

- **Discard half**, feed **50g white flour + 50g water**.
- Stir well. Mark the level carefully.
- Check every few hours — watch for rising!
- If it's rising, consider **feeding twice daily** (every 12 hours).

What to expect:

Around day 5 (sometimes 4, sometimes 6), you'll see real bubbles. The mixture will start to rise between feedings. The smell shifts from funky to pleasantly tangy, almost like yogurt. This is the moment you'll want to text someone a photo of flour paste. Go ahead. We've all done it.

***Tip:** Start feeding twice a day once you see consistent activity. This accelerates the culture development. Morning and evening works perfectly.*

"IT'S ALIVE! This is the sourdough equivalent of your baby's first smile. Enjoy this moment. You created life from flour and water."

Day 6

Building Strength

Your starter is a teenager now

Time needed: 5 minutes, twice a day

What to do:

- Feed **twice daily** now: morning and evening.
- Each time: **discard half**, add **50g flour + 50g water**.
- Watch how high it rises and how long it takes.
- Note the **peak time** — when it reaches its highest point.

What to expect:

Your starter should be rising noticeably between feedings. It might not be doubling yet, and that's fine. You're looking for consistent activity: it rises, peaks, and slowly falls. The smell should be pleasantly sour and yeasty.

***Tip:** The peak time tells you when your starter is at its strongest. This is when you'll eventually use it for baking. Most healthy starters peak 4-8 hours after feeding.*

"You're almost there. Your starter has developed its own personality by now — its own rhythm, its own smell, its own schedule. You're learning to read it like a parent learns to read their child."

Day 7

Ready to Bake!

The float test

Time needed: 5 minutes + excitement

What to do:

- Feed as usual. Wait until it's at its peak.
- **The Float Test:** Drop a small spoonful of starter into a glass of water.
- If it **floats** — congratulations, you're ready to bake!
- If it sinks — keep feeding for 2-3 more days. No rush.
- Give your starter a name. Seriously. It makes you care more.

What to expect:

A healthy, bake-ready starter doubles (or more) within 4-8 hours of feeding. It has a pleasantly tangy, yeasty aroma. It's bubbly throughout, not just on top. And it passes the float test.

***Tip:** Don't be discouraged if yours isn't ready on day 7. Some starters take 10-14 days, depending on your flour, water, and kitchen temperature. There is no wrong timeline — only your timeline.*

"You did it. You created a living culture from nothing but flour and water. This starter can now live for years — decades, even. Feed it, care for it, and it will give you incredible bread in return. Welcome to the sourdough family."

Troubleshooting Cheat Sheet

Don't panic. Almost every "problem" has a simple fix.

Symptom	Cause	Fix
Smells like nail polish	Hungry! Acetic acid buildup	Feed more frequently (2x/day)
Dark liquid on top ("hooch")	Very hungry	Pour off or stir in, then feed
No activity (days 4-6)	Good bacteria taking over	Keep feeding! This is normal
Pink/orange spots	Contamination (mold)	Discard all. Start fresh. It happens!
Not rising after 7 days	Too cold or weak flour	Move to warmer spot, try rye flour
Rises then falls quickly	Running out of food	Feed larger amounts or more often
Very runny/watery	Too much water	Adjust to thicker consistency
Forgot for 3+ days	Neglect (it happens!)	Feed 2-3 days, it will recover

Remember: sourdough starters have survived for thousands of years. They're incredibly resilient. If you're worried — just keep feeding. Time and consistency fix almost everything.

Your First Sourdough Loaf

The simplest recipe I know. Forgiving, reliable, and absolutely delicious.

Ingredients:

- **100g** active sourdough starter (at its peak, passes float test)
- **375g** water (room temperature)
- **500g** bread flour or all-purpose flour
- **10g** salt

Instructions:

- 1. Morning (9:00 AM) — Mix:** Combine starter, water, and flour in a large bowl. Mix until no dry flour remains. It will be shaggy and rough. That's perfect. Cover and let rest 30 minutes (this is called autolyse).
- 2. 9:30 AM — Add salt:** Sprinkle salt over the dough. Wet your hands and squeeze it in, folding the dough over itself until the salt is incorporated.
- 3. 10:00 AM to 1:00 PM — Stretch and fold:** Every 30 minutes, grab one side of the dough, stretch it up, and fold it over to the other side. Rotate the bowl and repeat 4 times. Do this every 30 minutes for the first 2 hours (4 sets total), then let it rest.
- 4. 1:00 - 5:00 PM — Bulk rise:** Let the dough sit covered at room temperature. It should grow by about 50% in volume. This can take 3-5 hours depending on temperature.
- 5. 5:00 PM — Shape:** Gently pour dough onto a lightly floured surface. Shape into a round by folding the edges toward the center, then flip it over seam-side down. Let it rest 20 minutes.
- 6. 5:20 PM — Final shape:** Shape again, gently but with purpose. Place seam-side UP into a bowl lined with a floured towel (or a banneton). Cover tightly.
- 7. Overnight — Cold proof:** Put the covered bowl in the fridge. Sleep. Dream of bread.
- 8. Next morning — Bake:** Preheat oven to 250°C (480°F) with your Dutch oven inside for 45 minutes. Take dough from fridge, turn onto parchment paper, score with a sharp blade, and lower into hot pot. Cover. Bake 20 minutes. Remove lid. Bake 20-25 more minutes until deep golden brown. Cool completely before cutting (hardest part!).

Your first loaf won't be perfect. It might be flat, dense, or oddly shaped. That's not failure — that's your first lesson. Eat it warm with butter and be proud.

Feeding Schedule Template

Print this page and stick it on your fridge. Track your starter's progress day by day.

Day	Date	Time Fed	Flour Used	Bubbles?	Rise?	Smell	Notes
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							
9							
10							
11							
12							
13							
14							

Starter's name: _____ Started on: _____

Pro tip: Take a photo of your starter every day at the same time. After a week, scroll through them — you'll be amazed at the transformation. Or even better: use the Rise & Ferment app to track everything automatically!

After Day 7: Living with Your Starter

Now that your starter is alive and active, here's how to keep it happy long-term.

If you bake weekly:

Keep your starter in the fridge. Feed it once a week: take it out, discard half, feed 50g flour + 50g water, let it sit at room temperature for a few hours until active, then back to the fridge. The day before you want to bake, take it out and give it 2-3 feedings at room temperature to get it strong and bubbly.

If you bake daily:

Keep it at room temperature and feed twice daily. You'll have a very active, very reliable starter.

Going on vacation?

Feed your starter, put it in the fridge, and forget about it. Starters can survive 3-4 weeks in the fridge without feeding. When you're back, it might look grey and separated (hooch on top). That's fine. Pour off the liquid, feed it 2-3 times over a couple of days, and it'll bounce right back.

What to do with discard:

Don't throw it away! Sourdough discard is incredible in pancakes, waffles, pizza dough, crackers, banana bread, and even pasta. The Rise & Ferment app has a full section of discard recipes. Your kids (or your inner child) will thank you.

"In a world that's constantly trying to sell us faster, cheaper, more convenient — choosing to make something with your own hands, slowly, with patience and a living culture that literally needs you... that's a small act of resistance."

You're part of something bigger now.

Rise & Ferment isn't just an app. It's a community of people who believe that making things with your hands matters. That helping each other matters. That slowing down isn't weakness — it's wisdom.

Continue your journey:

- **Download the app:** Track your starter, get smart reminders, explore recipes. Free at riseandferment.com
- **Join the community:** @riseandferment on Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube
- **Read the blog:** New guides and honest tips every week at riseandferment.com/blog
- **Subscribe to the newsletter:** Weekly recipes and exclusive content straight to your inbox

*Rise against what doesn't serve you.
Let the good things ferment slowly.
And when in doubt — knead.*

With love and flour dust,

The Rise & Ferment Team

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